



CELEBRATING 50 YEARS
SEVENOAKS
ATHLETICS CLUB



1976 - 2026

OUR HISTORY

From the earliest athletics in Sevenoaks
to 50 years of the modern club

1885 | 1976 | 2026

A club with a long history

Athletics in Sevenoaks predates the modern club by almost a century.

Sevenoaks Athletics Club in its present form dates from 1976, but organised athletics in the town reaches much further back. Newspaper archives contain references to a junior athletics club in Sevenoaks as early as 1885.

Across the decades the names, venues and events have changed, but familiar themes keep returning: young athletes, club races and handicaps, competition, Knole Park and the work of volunteers who have kept athletics thriving in the town.

SEVENOAKS JUNIOR ATHLETIC CLUB.

This club, which owes its origin to the energy of Master H. Simmonds and Master Laurie Oldfield (supported by their young friends), had its first competition for prizes on Saturday last, upon the piece of ground situated between Granville and Eardley roads. Mr. Lovett and Mr. Oldfield interested themselves in the events of the day, and when the members and visitors arrived they found that the course was mown, marked out with flags, and tents were erected for the exhibition of prizes and for refreshments. These last were provided by Mrs. Ledger, Mrs. Lovett, Mrs. Oldfield, and the club, and were in requisition by the competitors and their friends during a short interval allowed for rest.

The following is a list of the competitors:—
Division 1.—H. Devitt, P. Horwood, G. E. Jones D. Reid, H. Simmonds, E. G. Simmonds, M. Webb. Division 2.—A. Cosser, H. W. Jones, B. Ledger, H. J. Lovett, L. G. Oldfield, P. Simmonds.

The events came off in the following order:—
HIGH JUMP (Prize, moist paint box) 1st division, E. G. Simmonds; (moist paint box) 2nd, P. Simmonds.

THROWING CRICKET BALL (writing case), 1st E. G. Simmonds; (bows and arrows), 2nd, P. Simmonds.

LONG JUMP (crest album), 1st, H. Devitt; (tape measure), 2nd, Bertie Ledger.

PULLING THE WEIGHT (fret saw), 1st, H. Simmonds; (bows and arrows), 2nd, Bertie Ledger.

QUARTER MILE RACE (a book), 1st, P. Horwood; (box of note paper), 2nd, H. W. Jones.

THREE-LEGGED RACE (inkstand and fishing rod), P. Horwood and H. Simmonds.

CONSOLATION RACE (knife), G. E. Jones.

VISITORS' RACE (tin moist colour box), 1st, — Holford; (paint box), 2nd, Harry Devitt.

Owing to the kindness of Mrs. Wharton Johnson, Mr. Devitt, Mr. Swaffield, and Mr. Young, sufficient "consolation" prizes were offered to allow of every competitor getting some-

thing. The following were donors of prizes—Mr. Butterfield, Madame Charbonnier, Mrs. Devitt, Mrs. Ledger, Mr. Lovett, Mr. Oldfield, Miss Simmonds, Mr. Simmonds, Miss Thompson, and Mrs. Webb. The friends of other competitors kindly subscribed to the club funds. Mr. Eames, of the High-street, presented a bottle of sweets.

The sports commenced at half-past two and terminated at half-past five; and the various events were contested with great spirit, and the interest was on an ascending scale from the commencement to the finish. The parents and friends of the competitors were present in great force, and it was a very pretty sight to see young Sevenoaks jumping, racing, &c. &c. A most enjoyable afternoon was brought to a close by the presentation of prizes; this pleasing duty devolved upon Mrs. Lovett, and was carried out in a most kind and graceful manner,—a few words of congratulation being addressed to each recipient.

Sevenoaks Junior Athletic Club, 1885

An early sports meeting and prize giving

From club meetings to a sporting community

The archive gives glimpses of the people, places and traditions behind the club.

SEVENOAKS INVICTA ATHLETIC CLUB.

The opening run of the Sevenoaks Invicta Athletic Club was held on Wednesday night, the 21st inst. Only eight members turned out, among them being Messrs. Walker, (Captain,) A. W. Thompson, Ortnor, Golding, Aylo, and Allen. A start was made at 7.30 from headquarters, the Lime Tree Hotel. Thompson making the pace, the route taken was Tonbridge Road, the Common, out in the Tonbridge Road again above the White Hart and back to Headquarters. The distance is close upon three miles, and considering the bad state of the roads and the darkness in places, the time of 18 minutes is very good. The time was taken by Mr R. F. Holland.

After the return home, a Smoking Concert was held in the Concert Room, about 50 people being present. The attendance would no doubt have been much larger but for several other attractions being on at the same time in the town. The chair was taken by Mr R. Ratcliffe, (vice-captain,) in the absence of Mr Bath, who attended at the commencement, but owing to a death was unavoidably obliged to leave. A good programme of songs and instrumental music was gone through, and everyone present seemed to enjoy themselves. The following are the names of those who so kindly took part:—Miss Guest, piano, Miss Palmer, Messrs. Bradford, Grainger, Lamperd, Jeffries, (whose recitations were much appreciated,) Ortnor (dumb-political speech,) Jeffery, Marchant, and A. Marchant, (trombone) to whom many thanks are due. The concert closed at 10.30 with the singing of the National Anthem, and after the usual votes of thanks had been accorded to those taking an active part. This is the first concert the club has held, and it proved a success.

The Committee propose holding another in a month or six weeks, as also a dance. The number of members in the Club is under 20 at present, but it is hoped and no doubt there will be a good number of members before the end of the year. The only thing which debars many from joining now is the doubt as to whether they are professional runners or not, but they can very quickly find this out, by writing to the Hon. Secretary of the Amateur Athletic Association, 10 John Street, Adelphi, London, who will advise them of the proper course to take in order to get reinstated as an amateur, if there is any need for reinstatement.

The second run of this club was held on Wednesday evening last, the route being High Street, Oak Lane to Kippington Road and Tubs Hill, back to Headquarters. The following ran:—Walker, (Captain,) Simpson, (Hon. Sec.) Fyle, Hobbs, Budgen, Spencer and Ashton. The pace was made rather fast by the captain until half way up Tubs Hill when he was obliged to give up, and eventually only the Hon. Sec. ran through to Headquarters. The time was not taken. It is a pity more did not take part. The next run is fixed for Wednesday evening next. Start at 7.30 sharp.

Sevenoaks Invicta Athletic Club, 1891

SEVENOAKS ATHLETIC CLUB. — A meeting of the Committee of the newly-formed Athletic Club was held at the Drill Hall on Tuesday evening, when the following members were present: Messrs. J. Wright (President), Aves, Drinkwater, Morris and Pidwell. Mr. C. Orchard was elected Hon. Secretary, and it was decided that the title of the Club should be "The Sevenoaks and District Athletic and Cycle Club." The costume adopted was white vest, with the Sevenoaks shield, and black shorts. For the present the Headquarters of the Club will be at the Drill Hall, Colonel J. D. Laurie having kindly offered the use of a room for changing, etc. The object of the Club is to encourage athletics generally, but it is proposed to pay special attention to running, cycling, walking and boxing. The Club already numbers among its members men who are fairly well up in these branches, and it is hoped that everyone who is interested in any of them will apply for membership, and in this way help to restore to Sevenoaks the reputation it held in the world of sport prior to the war. Enquiries re membership should be addressed to Mr. Orchard, 29, Victoria-road, Sevenoaks.

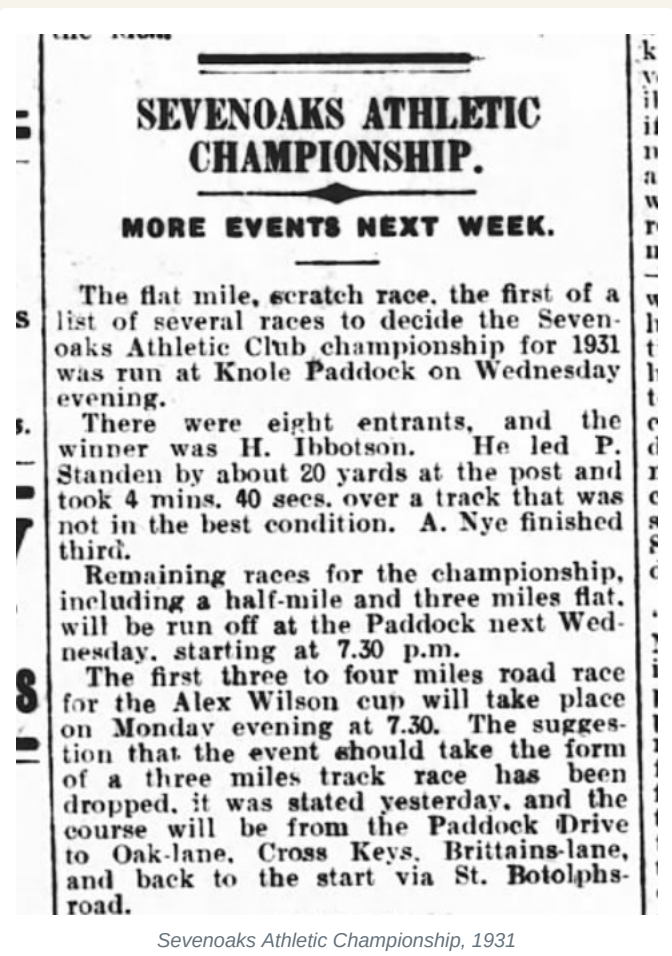
Sevenoaks Athletic Club, 1919

By 1919 the Sevenoaks and District Athletic and Cycle Club was being restored after the First World War. Its interests included running, cycling, walking and boxing, and the club adopted a white vest bearing the Sevenoaks shield with black shorts.

These reports show that athletics in Sevenoaks was never only about results. Meetings, concerts, prizes and volunteers were all part of club life - something that still feels familiar today.

Knole, championships and handicaps

Club racing was well established by the 1930s.



Sevenoaks Athletic Championship, 1931



The Wilson Cup road races

Knole Paddock appears repeatedly in the newspaper archive as a home for local athletics. In 1931 the club championship included the mile, half mile, three miles and a Wilson Cup road race.

The Wilson Cup became part of a long tradition of club handicap racing. The format gave runners of different abilities the chance to compete together - a club tradition that has survived in different forms across generations.

A club that refused to disappear

The archive records setbacks, rescue and repeated attempts to rebuild.



Tye's Cricket Club offers a temporary home, 1927



Revival prospects and plans for the future, 1937

In 1927 Sevenoaks Athletic Club was facing a very real problem: it had lost the use of its ground and, according to the Chronicle, there was a risk that the club could simply fade away. Tye's Cricket Club stepped in and offered temporary use of its Bradbourne Road ground while the club searched for a longer term home.

A decade later the newspaper was again reporting on revival plans, including cross country, track championships and renewed efforts to strengthen membership. The story of Sevenoaks athletics is not one of uninterrupted growth, but of a club repeatedly finding ways to continue.

The modern club

Re-established in 1976. Celebrating 50 years in 2026.



The Sevenoaks Athletics Club we know today dates from 1976. Over the following decades the club developed junior and senior athletics, road running, cross country and track and field.

Today the club has more than 200 members. The faces change, but the traditions seen throughout the archive remain familiar: training together, competing for the club, supporting one another and giving time to keep athletics thriving in Sevenoaks.

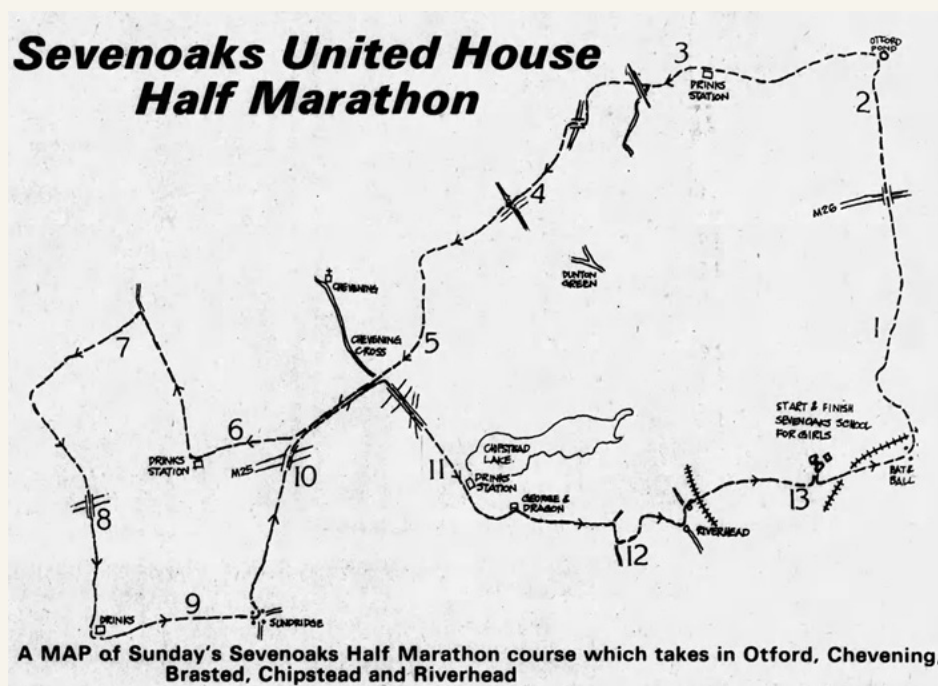


50 YEARS OF THE MODERN CLUB

1976 - 2026

The Sevenoaks Half Marathon

Fundraising, facilities and a major local road race.



The Sevenoaks Half Marathon was launched in 1986, ten years after the modern club was re-established, as part of the drive to raise funds for better facilities. The race started and finished at Sevenoaks School for Girls in Bradbourne Road, now Knole Academy, and at its height attracted up to 1,000 runners each year.

Alongside the half marathon were one mile and two mile fun runs for younger athletes. Between 1986 and the final race in 1993, the event raised around £2,500 to £3,000 a year for the club. The final Half Marathon was held in 1993, the same year the first Sevenoaks 7 took place.

Finding a permanent training base

Facilities remained a recurring challenge. Former committee member Chris Rowley later recalled spending two years developing plans for a new running track. Athletics authorities instead encouraged the club to make shared use of the existing track at Sevenoaks School.

A practical agreement followed, giving the club regular access to the track. Sevenoaks AC also helped provide equipment and storage, including container units and funding for pole vault and jumping equipment. This established the relationship with Sevenoaks School that remains central to the club today.

The club today



Today Sevenoaks AC has more than 200 junior and senior members, with athletes taking part in road running, cross country and track and field.

Sevenoaks School is our main training base, while Knole Park remains at the heart of club life through weekly runs, racing and events.

The details have changed since those first newspaper reports, but the thread running through the story is the same: people coming together to train, compete, volunteer and enjoy athletics.



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50 YEARS OF THE MODERN CLUB

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and more than 140 years of athletics in Sevenoaks

SEVENOAKS ATHLETICS CLUB